

Q+A

BACK TO NATURE

Releasing on June 24, Sherdil: The Pilibhit Saga *is yet another film that will see* **Pankaj Tripathi** *in the lead. But the actor insists he's no hero*

Q. Like your earlier film *Kaagaz*, *Sherdil: The Pilibhit Saga* is about an ordinary man caught in extraordinary circumstances. Is it more difficult to play an ordinary man than, let's say, a hero?
It's difficult to make audiences feel the presence of a powerless man. I enjoy playing someone who isn't a hero. I consider myself powerless. We actors live under an illusion that we have a huge following on social media and fans surrounding us. That's false power.

Q. *Sherdil* is perched on your shoulders. Has your work on OTT encouraged filmmakers to cast you in lead parts in features?
That may be true because my OTT shows (*Mirzapur* and *Criminal Justice*) are some of the most watched. You could also say that for my films *Mimi* and *Kaagaz* in 2021; *Gunjan Saxena* and *Ludo* in 2020. There's a belief now that I can pull off a film on my own.

Q. What did you take away from playing Ganga Ram in *Sherdil*?
Love and appreciation for nature. When I lived in a village, I hadn't even heard of pollution. Only when I started living in a concrete jungle did the awareness dawn that we hadn't valued what we had then. I live in Madh [Island] now because from my window I get to see the expanse of the sky.

Q. Given that it is set in a jungle, shooting it must have been a joy then...
Of all my films, I enjoyed shooting this the most. We shot in the forests of West Bengal. We stayed at a tea estate and I'd walk every morning and get a view of the Kanchenjunga. The Teesta and Murti rivers are beautiful. I can keep talking about my love for nature.

–with Suhani Singh